

THE LAGGARDS

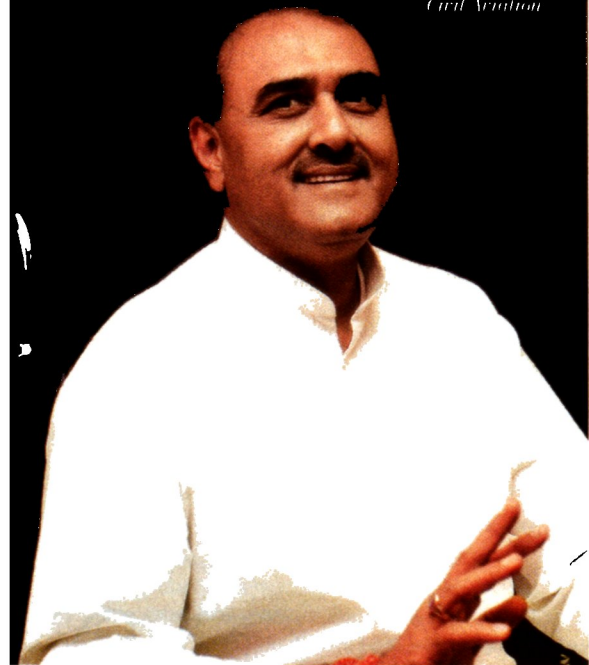
PRAFUL PATEL

Civil Aviation Minister*

● **AGENDA** Unlike others, he did not announce a 100-day programme. But was it because he saw turbulent times ahead?

● **PERFORMANCE** The economic downturn has eaten away a third of the passenger air traffic, government-owned Air India is bleeding to the tune of Rs 200 crore a month and private airlines are clamouring for a bailout package in what can only be termed as 'privatisation of profit and nationalisation of debt'. Patel, who is now pushing for a Group of Ministers to bring down the Aviation Turbine Fuel surcharge, is yet to get a smooth landing on any of his ministry's problems. Patel is accused of taking sides with some of the country's more profligate and reckless operators.

** Minister of State (Independent Charge) of the Ministry of Civil Aviation*



YASBANT NEGI

A.K. ANTONY

• **Defence Minister**



SIPRA DAS

● **AGENDA** In his second term Antony continues to maintain an extremely low-profile, though his tasks are mammoth—modernising the defence forces, dealing with shortfall of personnel and an unstable neighbourhood—a belligerent Pakistan and an unpredictable China.

● **PERFORMANCE** His crusade against corruption in the system, which many say is the only reason why he was brought in, continues. Two key foreign vendors were blacklisted for allegedly paying bribes to a government official. Yet it is unclear whether he has grasped the complex long-term defence and security issues which his ministry is tasked with. If only he would articulate his thoughts.

SUSHILKUMAR SHINDE

• **Power Minister**

● **AGENDA** As part of the ministry's 'power for all' project, Shinde laid out a capacity addition target of 5,653 MW. To speed up rural electrification, he set the target of extending electricity connections to 12 lakh BPL households and Shinde promised close monitoring of all power projects.

● **PERFORMANCE** Against the promised capacity addition, the Ministry has achieved only 4,123 MW. Targets have been set but none achieved. Ultra mega power projects are yet to be announced. Similarly, no word either on increased private sector role in transmission or inter-state supply of power.



RAVISH SAHANI